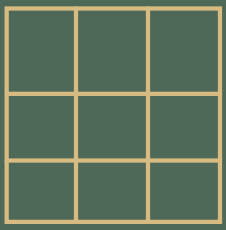
HISTORIES OF OUR WORLD

Lines on the Land



GEOGRAPHY

The Den Editions

ORIGINAL SAMPLE ESSAY

01 / GEOGRAPHY

A map has a purpose

A historical map is both a picture of a place and an object made for a purpose. Surveyors measured land, mapmakers selected information, and printers turned those choices into something others could use. Roads, boundaries, and place names did not all receive equal attention.

The Library of Congress preserves maps made for many different tasks. Comparing them reveals that there is no single view of a landscape. A military map and a county map might describe the same ground while answering very different questions.

02 / GEOGRAPHY

Reading the silences

During the nineteenth century, detailed county maps and large wall maps helped people represent a changing United States. Printing methods made it easier to reproduce and distribute geographical information. A map could become a working tool or a display on a wall.

When reading one, examine its date, maker, scale, and intended audience. Then ask what it leaves out. A boundary records a claim or administrative arrangement; it does not by itself explain everyone who lived there. The omissions are part of the evidence.

About this edition

This is a modern original sample essay created for The Den's public demo. It is not a historical original or a transcription of a historical document. The prose and geometric cover artwork were created for this collection.

Sources and further reading
These museum and library pages informed the historical details. Follow the links to explore their fuller accounts and collections.

Library of Congress: Single-Sheet Maps

https://guides.loc.gov/maps-illustrated-guide/single-sheet-maps

Library of Congress: Maps in Our Lives

https://loc.gov/exhibits/maps/

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